True as it can be

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/54975709.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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Castaspella/Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Characters:
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by Iwaseatingthosebeans

Summary

They said that the Beast had died that night. Drained of her power by Micah’s curse. Left to rot in Mystacor’s halls.

Of course - rumours weren't always too accurate.

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

She knew the stories they told.

The stories of Mystacor's traitor, of Hordak's commander. Two tales marked by two curses. Two tales that ended the same.

Curses. Dark magic. Parasitic things. Vengeful and starving, clawing from the shadows with frenzied abandon. They were not to be trusted, and yet she had followed them willingly. And now they stalked her, stained her path with indelible horrors.

The first tale was of her death. And the birth of a grey-fleshed creature, gouged and mangled with reptilian eyes. The Spell of Obtainment had rendered Light Spinner unrecognisable. Unredeemable. Exiled. She had heard their whispers. Whispers of the Beast. The Beast who fled Mystacor. The beast who savagely murdered the headmaster and crawled to the other side of the war, to the Horde where it belonged.

The second tale told of the Horde's sorcerer. Hordak's commander, cold and covert behind the mask. The Beast could be half respectable when it remained obscured, though she was no less despised. This tale ended where the first had begun, in the manner and place from which she had been banished.

The Battle of Mystacor had been a failure. A failure only surpassed by Hordak's own defeat in the subsequent days.

Shadow Weaver touched the bell jar. Carefully, she lifted it, to the only magical substance that remained here. It was a powerful incantation, though it was unpolished. Likely a draft, a last resort. The memory made her hair rise. She'd never expect forgiveness from Micah, yet the hatred in his casting had left something bitter in her throat.

Her fingertip brushed the underside of a petal. So frail and velvet-soft. The magic pulsed against her finger, and for a moment she was lost in her own enamourment. Magic. Its humming energy. Pure.

With a soft crackle, the petal fell. Shadow Weaver withdrew her hand. Stiffly, she replaced the jar.

They said that the Beast had died that night. Drained of her power by Micah's curse. Left to rot in Mystacor's halls.

They were half right. It was hardly a life cowering here. The gnawing despair in her stomach served as a sole reminder that to live was to suffer. She was a beetle in a jar, a rat in a well, scrambling between the rigidity of her past and an aimless future.

The remainder of her life was mapped in petals and it would be lived with little more than regret.

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"Allow me to demonstrate the technique in which we burn the petals. Like this!"

It was a very pleasant morning. The birds were chirping, the birdbath was smoking, Perfuma's protests regarding the hazards associated with conjuring fires in the middle of Brightmoon's gardens were but a distant afterthought, and Casta's all time favourite student had given her the time of day. Or - well. A very tiny fragment of her day.

"Uh. I appreciate you offering to teach me, Aunt Casta," Glimmer expressed, strained. "But, you know - Dad's been showing me plenty of spells too. Honestly, I'm pretty magicked out for the day."

"Oh. I see." Casta discarded the stem, setting it ablaze. So… perhaps sticking to the traditional candles and such would have been a better first approach after all. And yet she had initially thought against it with Glimmer's impatient - no, *eager*

disposition….she dusted her robe vigorously, brushing away her dismay. "Well, if you need any assistance, Glimmer, don't hesitate to ask me. My assistance is known to be absolutely *legendary...* "

"I'm sure I'll be fine , " Glimmer sighed. She brightened. "Actually, I'm going to meet Bow and Adora for brunch now. And Catra. You mentioned Dad - um, surely he's back soon?"

Ah, yes. Micah. Given their shared residency in Brightmoon, finding him shouldn't have been so difficult. Except that, when he wasn't helping Glimmer or performing royal duties, Micah disappeared to spend time alone. The war had granted him custody of too many memories. He shouldered them and he took care of them, but they offered him little respite. And he was still unused to company, she could tell. The war had changed them all.

Bidding her niece an affectionate goodbye, *"I'm so glad you're making time for your friends!"* Casta left the gardens. She passed Perfuma on her way out, receiving a frown of disappointment. Absolutely warranted, but oddly devastating at the same time. Before she could offer any kind of smile or recompense, Scorpia appeared, looping their arms together. They both turned, smiling giddily at each other.

Casta headed into the castle, not at all nauseated.

Of all the places to settle, Brightmoon was certainly one of the nicest. Where it lacked Mystacor's cosy privacy and sharp elegance, it very nearly made up for it in sheer charm. Such a delicate place. Pink and pleasant with soft furniture and long windows. She had enjoyed her visits to the kingdom before the war, before Micah's supposed death, before Angella had stopped writing to her and Glimmer had stopped visiting and she believed that the Horde had consumed everything she held dear.

She'd gotten most of her life back in one piece. Most. Like any of her borrowed books or stationary or cake tins, they never returned to her quite the same.

Casta slowed before the portrait hall. Queen Angella sat poised, regal and sharply beautiful in the end frame.

Micah was not here.

She allowed her gaze to pass over the frame, never quite reaching the eyes. Whatever bond they had shared in the early days of Glimmer's childhood was long gone. Angella had never mourned it quite like she had.

Mind flashing briefly to Glimmer, she turned in the direction of the war room…

…right into a guard.

"Ow!"

The clash of metal sent her reeling towards the wall, knocked windless.

"Ugh." She grumbled, scowling. "Are you hurt? I'd imagine not, with steel for clothes - you should really look where you're goi-"

"Castspella, I'm so - Your Majesty. I apologise." The guard leaned forward to stabilise her, eyes dark and warm and recognisable in a way that sucked the heat from Casta's stomach.

"Juliet?"

General Juliet straightened. "I am deeply sorry. Your Majesty. It won't happen again."

'I'm not…" Casta blinked. Her throat refused to open.

"Um. Casta? Glimmer told me you wanted to talk." She heard her brother approach from behind her.

Dizzily, she nodded. "Micah!" She swallowed. "Yes. I wish to discuss…things."

"Sure." Micah glanced at the door ahead. "War room?"

***

It would be bordering on treason to suggest that Queen Glimmer's wisest investment yet had been the war room swivel chairs…but they had been quite a big deal at the time, causing a surprising amount of controversy after Brightmoon's funds had been redirected from military resources. And they were extremely comfortable. They were also a major factor in why she and Micah so often used the room for unwarlike conversations - after all, there were fewer meetings now - surely they wouldn't want the chairs to go to waste?

"Fifteen crocheted penguins?" Micah spun slowly. "I just…no, I'm not saying it's too many, but…why?"

"It's just been a while since I had the chance to make them for her. She used to adore them, you know."

She tried to ignore the way his brow pinched at the reminder of Glimmer's childhood. "I understand," he said slowly. "Look Casta, I know you love her to bits, but Glimmer's worried that people still aren't taking her seriously."

"Of course I take her seriously! Glimmer has the makings of a great queen…strong, brave, resilient. *Powerful.* She must take after her Aunt." Casta folded her arms, chin lifted. "But, if she wishes, I will stick to scarves."

Micah's eyes twinkled, and she was almost reminded of his former self - even as in his face still lurked hints of grief and atrophy. "I'm glad to hear it," he grinned.

"Yes, well. Anything for my favourite niece."

From the corner of her eye, she could see Micah watching her curiously, though his posture remained casual. He stopped spinning. After a moment, he prompted, "You can tell me anything, Casta. Really."

Right. The reason she'd agreed to meet in the first place. She needed to stop stalling. Casta sat straighter.

"Well...I know that Mystacor may be in terrible shape - without magic, none of its functions will have held up, the wards will be down, it'll probably be overrun with bugs and wolves and without any of the pipe magic the plumbing will be all ruined...but I intend to rebuild it." She swallowed the self-consciousness in her tone. "I'd like to ask for your support."

To his credit Micah didn't laugh, though his brow furrowed. "In the same location? I don't think it's safe to return. Not with the curse intact."

She pressed further. "And if it isn't?"

"Then it won't be a problem." He stood. "But if it is... curses are difficult to break. And they're dangerous. I think we've been through enough danger for a lifetime." He looked at her, hopeful. "You could rebuild nearer to Brightmoon. Most of the surviving sorcerers live near here, anyway."

There wasn't much substance in arguing with her brother and his stubborn good nature. Especially when he wasn't exactly wrong. Yet, she could not forsake Mystacor so easily.

"I will consider it," she finally said. To be fair, there wasn't much use in arguing with her, either. She stood to meet him. "But I will scout Mystacor myself first."

***

She didn't intend to be gone for more than a couple of days. Micah had insisted that she bring a horse at least. And a weapon. And a party of guards. And a sack of granola bars, as he seemed certain that had the curse indeed broken, she would be intent on staying.

"I'll come with you," he had later offered, though reluctantly. They still disagreed. *"This isn't just a scouting mission, and we both*

know it."

"Surely I'm not so predictable. And you have responsibilities here, Micah. I'm perfectly capable of handling myself!" she had told him, and he had sighed and labelled her as stubborn. Like an absolute hypocrite.

Nevertheless, Casta took the horse.

She used to entertain the idea that Micah was Mystacor's prodigal son – too bright and clever to keep home. She was the one who stayed. Mystacor was hers to take care of in a way that it had never been Micah's. She had to see it now, if only to see it beyond hope of fixing.

The evening's purple hue had hardly faded from the tips of the trees before Casta's light incantation faded. A thickness settled over them - remnants of the curse, perhaps. So it remained. It probably would have been wise to turn back with this knowledge and leave it be, but wisdom was so easily overrun by her recklessness. She was drawn towards the gate.

With a sudden cry of distress, her horse surged upwards and Casta was sent sprawling into the weeds. As it galloped away, a low growl erupted above her.

Casta froze. Wolves. Her mind skipped to Mystacor's wards. The protection wards. There was no magic. They were inactive. Of course. The clarity was fleeting before teeth snapped beside her ear and she yanked back, scrambling towards the gate.

It barely scraped open before the wolf lunged at her, teeth sinking into her ankle. She reached into the hollow air - magic numb.

Weakly, she kicked out, catching a rib or a leg to loosen its teeth. Before another could attack, she slammed the gate shut. Her attacker snarled, teeth glittering against the bars. Wheezing, she suppressed the urge to curse at it (such habits were dangerous to indulge as a teacher).

Well. The wards were inactive. The journey back would be difficult.

Slowly, she rose, turning to face her former school. Rude as the welcome had been, she was glad to be back.

***

The hall unravelled before them, the carpet stretched out like a gold-speckled tongue. Casta stumbled forward, foot catching on Micah's robe. Glancing up, she half feared the place would swallow her whole.

Micah cast back a goofy grin. "Bring me a souvenir next time."

"Huh?"

"When you trip."

"Jerk."

Micah's smile widened. "It's cool though, isn't it? Who knows, maybe you'll even be stuck with me for some classes."

"Yeah?"

He hesitated. "Well - not for the first couple of years. But after that - yeah. For sure."

Micah could be an incredible liar sometimes.

The hall was dark, now. Cold. She lamented her temporary loss of magic. She'd have to retrieve some of the rune patterns from her office. Given that most of them lay scattered around the boundaries of the school rather than within it, they could be reactivated from the outside. Theoretically.

She was exceptional at theory. She enjoyed it - studying great works and creations and stories. She had become Head Sorceress

primarily from her theoretical work and knowledge of the school's historical legacy.

Practical matters, on the other hand, had always been more of Micah's expertise. She shook away a memory, a little too sharp, rounding the corner to her office.

Her hand grazed over the doorknob.

"Your Majesty?"

"Yes?"

"It's about your brother. The King. He's dead."

She opened the door.

With a vague visualisation of her possessions and a couple of calculated drawer-fumbles, Casta finally pulled out a handful of loose matches. She struck one clumsily, the spark crackling onto her torch. Matches weren't too commonly used – only provided to some of the younger students who couldn't cast properly.

Light bloomed around her, revealing her desk all dusty and cobwebbed, but ultimately as she'd left it. Well. Almost. Her bookcase was shifted to the side, chair oddly angled. There were runes vandalising her desk. Inactive, of course, but fresh. And highly inappropriate.

Her skin prickled, breath hitching as someone sneered in her ear.

"You dare to venture back here?"

Casta spun, thrusting the torch forward, but the figure had slunk back, invisible. "You're alive," she breathed, despising the tremble in her voice. "After *everything* you've done . "

"Obviously," came the reply. "I can only assume that you've come to fix your handiwork. Did you bring *Micah* , too?"

Her blood burned at his name. *How dare she?* "Micah has no interest in things of the past," she snapped. "Especially you."

She could almost hear the smirk, cutting further into a place of weakness. "Yes. I suppose he was always looking ahead, as one does, with a future as bright as his." The torch flickered. "Perhaps it is better that he is not here. Such curses affect the powerful more than any other."

Casta ignored the jab with narrowed eyes. The room's shadows remained still. In her hatred, a dark curiosity plagued her, hungry and insistent.

"Step into the light," she ordered softly.

There was a pause. A shift.

"You wish to see me?" The woman's tone carried an edge.

She didn't respond at first, glaring into the dim. Then she lowered her torch, slowly. "Please."

There was a movement. Slight. A twitch of consideration – or apprehension, in her peripheral. Casta jerked her torch to the side, hand reaching to seize Shadow Weaver's robe and bring the torch to her –

Oh.

Maskless. Scars twisted like brambles under hollowed cheekbones, over her nose, disappearing down her scarf. Slitted green eyes flashed in the firelight, lips pulled back in fury.

Shadow Weaver inhaled sharply, pulling back. She whipped around into the darkness and disappeared.

***

She steered clear from the west side of Mystacor most days, only stopping by the gardens in the faintest glow of the morning. The

library ate up most of her time, and she was vaguely reminded of the student life in Mystacor. It was a happy time, but fleeting. Others had gone on to become war heroes and advisors, yet she had stayed behind, alone.

Outside the library, she studied the art of curses, traced the runes on the south pillars of the school. Breaking a curse traditionally required the presence of a condition embedded. Something verbal like password usually, or a time limit, though many curses wore off eventually. When she had outlined the spell in the midst of battle, there had been no time to create conditions or failsafes. Micah had cast a draft - powerful, functional, but imperfect.

Of course - another avenue to breaking it would be to destroy the vessel.

The vessel.

The memory startled her awake, blinking up at the painted stars on the roof of her quarters. Drowsily, she slipped from her bed and down the dim lit corridor, headed for the library once again.

Curses were relatively straightforward. In theory. *An intention to cast it, a condition to end it, a bridge to channel it and a vessel to hold it.* The intention and the bridge were irrelevant now that the curse had taken hold.

Thankfully, the torches were still ignited from earlier that day. She trawled through the spines. Ancient things.

Pulling out a book, she flinched at a flash of scarlet. She felt her hackles rise. Shadow Weaver stood nearby. It was too late now to duck out now. She would not be intimidated. Although, she did wish that she wasn't in her pyjamas.

And that Mystacor's library was not so economically designed.

She sighed, glaring at the shelves, three times her size. More specifically, she glared at the fifth shelf up. Chaotic practices.

Counter curses. Damage control. It was a touch too high for her to reach, yet hardly worth lugging the stepladder over for.

Glancing around to ensure she was out of sight, Casta boosted herself up from the shelf below, finger tripping the spine of a volume. Gritting her teeth, she tried once more.

As she felt the book shift above her, a hand reached in from behind, plucking it away.

She gaped, outraged. "Do you *mind?"*

" *My Mother's a Leech: The Art of Draining* , *"* Shadow Weaver drawled, flipping a page over. "Taking a break from family, Castaspella?"

"It must have been placed incorrectly." Casta scowled as Shadow Weaver slid it back on the shelf.

"You will find scant evidence of anything useful here," she remarked, sweeping over the other books. "Norwyn feared the darker arts. He stripped the library bare decades ago."

"For good reason, too."

She received a sound of exasperation. "If you speak of the Spell of Obtainment, it was clearly a mistake - one of which I have paid the price for."

"Mistake?" Casta scoffed. "Please. You were a Horde commander for years . You chose your side many times over."

"You presume to know me-"

"I know enough," she interrupted. She had battled the Horde. She had battled the Beast. She had lived those stories and now they lay clear as day across her face. Shadow Weaver stared back, mouth twisted into a strange rictus.

Casta did not wait for her response.

***

"She's so precious."

"She is. And exhausting, but you'll probably learn that after today. It'll only be a couple of hours, Castaspella, I do apologise for the late notice -"

"Oh no, it's my pleasure, Angella. Really, I love children." She snuggled her, stroking Glimmer's cotton candy hair. She caught the Queen's odd expression. "She'll be comfortable here," she reassured. "Magically warmed formula, plush cots…I even acquired some organic baby powder!"

Angella shook her head. "I'm not worried," she said, though Casta wasn't so sure. She hovered in the doorway, wings twitching. "She's been demonstrating some magical tendencies. Your family's genes, I imagine." She pursed her lips, mock-annoyed. "It's been quite intense."

"I see." She smiled at tiny baby Glimmer, a warm, heavy bundle in her arms. "It should be no problem."

"You're good with her. I'm surprised you don't have any of your own."

Casta snorted. Mystacor's students were *her own, in a way. "I wouldn't have the time," she replied, a little wistful. "Although - I will* always *have time for Glimmer here."*

Angella nodded, seeming to swallow whatever she wanted to say. She turned to leave, but then glanced back. "Micah told me about Juliet."

Juliet.

The name stuck sharp like weeds in Casta's throat. Angella looked almost pitying in a way she would never have usually been. In a way she should never have been. They didn't have that kind of relationship. "I'm sorry it didn't work."

"Oh. It's fine." Her voice rang out, cheerful.

Really. It was *fine. She had always been alone. Some things were never meant to be.*

***

They were left outside her door the following morning.

Three neatly stacked books. All on curses. A condescending remark, most likely, or a thinly veiled murder attempt. Upon closer inspection (more specifically, determining that the pages were not laced with poison), Casta noted that they were definitely not from the library.

She flicked through them over the next couple of days out of a morbid curiosity. Fascinating (and disturbing) as they were, they didn't really provide too many viable solutions to the problem at hand.

"Condescending *and* useless," she noted. Nonetheless, she couldn't help wondering if Shadow Weaver possessed any other terrible readings.

The riper produce was unpicked on her subsequent journey to the gardens, borrowed books tucked under her arm. She had to admit, the prosperity of the gardens was surprising. Even without any magical enhancements, the results of pruning and watering was evident. She supposed that Shadow Weaver couldn't always have been allergic to sunlight and joy and good things in general.

She stepped into the greenhouse with little patience for Shadow Weaver's games, but decidedly limited options, unsurprised to find it full of plants, except for one of the dorm beds in the corner and a couple of books and baskets of produce near the door. And a lone table. It stood off to the side of the bed, against the wall.

On it sat a bell jar, a single red rose levitating within.

Magic. Her heart quivered at the sensation. Instinct tugged her forward, heat prickling in her fingers as she lifted the glass. Such a familiar spark of energy reminded her of how unnatural it felt to be deprived of it.

"Don't touch that." From the doorway, Shadow Weaver lurched forward, face white. It morphed into something wild as she twisted, shielding the rose and looming over Casta. "Get *out,"* she spat. "Get out!"

"Wait." Casta stepped back. "I came to return your books! Look - I thought we could compromise -"

"You sought to *kill* me." Her voice was breathless with fury - or fear - scars and teeth mangled in gruesome rage. None of her cold wrath, no remnant of her calculated commander's vengeance. Such was torn clean off to reveal something raw and vile beneath.

And really, at this point, Casta might as well have given murder a go, seeing as her own life expectancy was rapidly dwindling before her eyes. Her pity and bafflement was washed over with a feeling of stupidity - this woman was dangerous *,* this woman would *kill* her and here she was, alone, away from her family, sleeping in the same building, eating foods she had grown, *borrowing her books.* What was next? Braiding each other's hair? Being tossed off the balcony?

Suddenly not caring at all how afraid she seemed, Casta spun and hurried down to the gate and into the forest beyond.

She left.

Without having activated the wards.

She swore upon realising this. Loudly. Because really, she wouldn't live long enough at this rate to see it become a habit.

The wolves were on her before Mystacor was even from her line of sight. It was her fault, really. Maybe they could use her as a

cautionary tale for Mystacor's future generation to prevent midnight strolls in forests and to make children eat their vegetables.

A wolf latched onto her ankle, though before she could kick it off, another slammed her into the soil, claws gouging her robes, breath scalding her neck.

This whole journey had been for naught. She would never see Mystacor be rebuilt. She would never hug her brother again. She would never crochet another penguin. She would die alone in the middle of a forest, eaten alive in her mid-thirties, wearing her second-to-least favourite socks. Casta struggled, efforts waning.

And then the weight was gone.

Shadow Weaver gripped her upper arm, yanking her off the ground. "You imbecile - what were you thinking?" she snapped, panting. She shoved past another wolf with great effort. "You will kill us both."

The wolves appeared to be the lesser of two evils, Casta was tempted to point out, though it probably wasn't too helpful to the situation. She stared at her, considering her own gratitude. Shadow Weaver pushed her forward.

"Go!" she growled.

Swerving around snapping teeth and claws, Casta gripped Shadow Weaver's robe tightly as they stumbled back to Mystacor. It was easier with the two of them. Almost. At the gate, a wolf lashed out, claws tearing down Shadow Weaver's side. She hissed and buckled, and summoning the last of her energy, Casta all but dragged them both inside.

They collapsed into the common rooms, Casta's forearm damp with the other woman's blood. Why she had followed was beyond her.

She tugged down Shadow Weaver's sleeve, grimacing at the wound on her shoulder. With a cloth and a cup of warm saline from the kitchens, she cleaned it gently, feeling her tense beneath, though she did not protest. It should have felt wrong, tending to someone whose crimes had once burned her so terribly. Casta clenched her jaw as she dabbed, silently noting the scars etched along her collarbone, down her shoulder and into her robes below. Faded. The angry gash of crimson on her shoulder would no doubt blend in with the others when it healed.

"You saved me." The words came out flat, and exasperation flickered over Shadow Weaver's face.

"I do not wish to be accused of murder should the Queen or your brother or one of your students come searching for you." It was said so smoothly that Casta was unsure if she fully believed her. It hardly mattered at this point, anyway.

"Well…thank you anyway." She exhaled. "But you really ought to control your temper."

"And evade your incessant criticism? Now, why would I do that?" Shadow Weaver shifted, ignoring her disapproval. "You came to destroy the rose, no? I suppose that you would be aware that is acts as a receptacle for the curse."

"That was never the plan."

"No. You intended for me to hold the curse myself." She turned away. "As I will. Soon."

This gave her pause. "What do you mean?"

"Curses are parasitic by nature, yes? They feed off of the magic in a living thing. Micah chose to anchor it to me through the proxy of a rose…no doubt in the hopes that I would perish immediately." Shadow Weaver huffed. "Which I did not, clearly. However, should the rose die, it will transfer to me."

"And while you are drained of your magic..."

“I will die.”

There was a strange note to her tone and Casta briefly wondered if such an easy escape was ever tempting. Shadow Weaver glanced at her shrewdly, a burning sensation. “It is not so painless to be eaten alive.”

Casta brushed the scar on the base of her neck, featherlight. The mark of having been devoured whole and surviving. “No,” she agreed. “I would imagine not.”

Shadow Weaver stilled. She pulled away. Her voice was odd as she readjusted her robe, rising from the couch. “Why are you here, if not to kill me?”

Casta straightened, her own candour surprising. “I intend to break the curse. Restore Mystacor to its former glory. Our remaining sorcerers deserve as much.”

“You intend to break it? Without killing me.” Shadow Weaver scoffed. “It is impossible. Surely even you recognise that.”

“I don’t like to solve my problems by killing people in cold blood,” Casta countered, lifting her gaze. “We are not the same.”

“Delusional and self-righteous? You may have a point.” Shadow Weaver scowled down at her. “There are no easy options this time, Castaspella. You will fail one way or another.”

Chapter End Notes

Thanks for reading. I enjoyed writing this, but reading over my own stuff makes me want to barf, so apologies if some of it's weird or poorly edited.

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

There wasn't much point in returning to Brightmoon now. Even Micah's theoretical knowledge on curses hardly rivalled that of her own - save for maybe the Spell of Obtainment, given the time he and Shadow Weaver wasted on it (though ironically, the most knowledgeable individual on such a curse lived several corridors away).

She returned to the library to source more books on methods of weakening links and transferring vessels, but, unfortunately Shadow Weaver had been quite right about Mystacor's limited material. Of course she had - being so familiar with such material herself.

Perhaps if she badgered the woman for some more of her illicit readings…

No.

Shadow Weaver had made her stance clear. And Casta was too proud to beg.

***

"Oh, come on. It's mutually beneficial!"

"I am not a library, Castaspella," Shadow Weaver sniffed. "Very little of my more…discreet material survived the purge of my quarters after I left."

She made an annoying amount of sense. Casta folded her arms. "Do you really expect me to kill you?"

“I expect that you’re stubborn enough not to.” The woman leaned against the back wall of the greenhouse, imperious as ever. “I was more in favour of you leaving me to pass in peace,” she continued offhandedly. “Though I assume that this is not a likely option.”

“Do you have any *helpful* suggestions?”

“If I did, then we would not be having this conversation, would we?”

Casta sighed. It seemed that an alternative tactic was required. She pulled a bottle of wine from her satchel. A nice red one. She extended it. “Humour me.”

Her expression was almost worth the visit alone. Shadow Weaver’s voice was quiet, clearly taken aback. “I did not realise Mystacor had a cellar.”

Casta grimaced. “It doesn’t. This is mine.”

“I see. Did you bring this on your journey from Brightmoon in lieu of food and supplies, or were you in the habit of ruling Mystacor intoxicated?”

“It’s a versatile present for staff!” Casta defended. It was true - she had resorted to some more generic gifts after finding quite a ridiculous number of her knitted goods in the charity box - most of which had been given to *Mystacor’s teachers* , of all people. The betrayal was gutting. “And very occasionally, it was a weekend indulgence.”

She earned a snort of derision. “Of course it was.”

“Oh, don’t tell me you never drank with the Horde. It’s the perfect way to drown your conscience.”

She received a sly glance, as if Shadow Weaver was almost impressed at her boldness. “Rarely,” she replied. “Most of the Horde’s resources were directly put towards furthering the reach of the Empire. Not much was reserved for recreational purposes.”

“Well. I don’t expect much more from a group like that.” Casta peered closely. A persistent curiosity prompted her to ask, “You do regret your allegiance, don’t you?”

Shadow Weaver hesitated, then glanced away, a painting of nonchalance. Her hair fell over her shoulder as she turned, shrouding her features. “Clearly I have made poor decisions in the past, for which I have paid the price. My allegiance with the Horde, whether you may consider it consequence or cause, is relevant to both.” Her tone flattened and it was clear she would not address the issue further. Casta gave a stiff nod.

“I’m glad you can acknowledge that much.”

Shadow Weaver looked at her, then down at the wine. Then back at her again. She pressed her mouth into a straight line. “Do you intend for us to drink from the bottle?”

Casta flushed at the idea. “I assumed you had some sort of glassware or crockery in here…” She eyed the lonely wooden bowl in the corner and sighed. “We’d best go to the kitchens.”

***

“Light Spinner. She was a scar on Mystacor’s past...”

“Sometimes I think you’re a little obsessed with that story, Aunt Casta.”

“Oh.” Casta cleared her throat. “Is there another one you would like to hear?”

Glimmer sighed, donning a new haircut and a new kind of exasperation towards her aunt. “I’m grateful that you’re having me over. Really. But I’ve heard all of them already.” She gazed at the statue above, jaw set. “Mom grounded me last week for joining the resistance in Plumeria. She doesn’t understand that I can’t live on stories forever.”

And she could have tutored her then - provided an avenue with which she could harness her magic. Glimmer certainly carried Micah's power within her. Raw power and talent. With all her brazenness and her steady diet of heroic tales, she would have no qualms in taking that power to face Hordak head-on. And…to be struck down on the battlefield like her father.

Swiftly, Casta quashed the notion, clasping her hands together. "Would you like a muffin instead?"

***

She tapped the spine of the book, glaring into the midday sun. "What do you think about transferring the curse between vessels?"

Shadow Weaver glanced up from the potato patch. Her hair shifted at the movement in trained grace, smoothing like feathers down the length of her back. "Even if you were to succeed, transferring will only serve to prolong it, not weaken it."

"I am aware of that. But if we could find a way to unbind it from *you* -"

"It is *not* bound to me. Yet. By the time that happens, it will be too late."

"That is a fair point." Her reasoning and general knowledge was impressive sometimes. Had she not been such a terrible person, Shadow Weaver's teaching career would probably have been quite successful. Quite a shame - they were always so short of staff. Not that they currently had a school. Or students.

Her gaze wandered over her jaw, sunlight dappled over cracks in pearly skin. She wondered sometimes, what had happened to her mask. Shadow Weaver was not one to relinquish her facade so easily.

"Is there something else you wish to say?"

Casta twirled a hair behind her ear. Apparently her scrutiny was not appreciated. “Save me some,” she said after a moment. “I think I’ve eaten enough tomatoes for a lifetime. Could really use some complex carbohydrates.”

***

“All right. How about transmuting *the curse itself* into, say…”

“Edible substances?”

Casta squinted down at the print on the book cover. They stood outside in the shadow of the greenhouse building. She knew that Shadow Weaver didn’t quite trust her within proximity of the rose.

Edible Transmutations, the cover read.

“I hadn’t actually heard of anything like it before now. Of course, it might be absolutely useless, but I wanted to check if you had heard of anything similar?”

Her lips twitched, and Casta noticed the glint of fangs through her scarred cleft - small and sharp. *Too small to eat whole children for breakfast.* Perhaps some of her stories needed to be amended.

“You are not familiar with the author, are you?” she inclined her head. “I suppose his infamy was before your time.”

“I take it that you know him?”

“Not personally. He was no Horde soldier, if that is what you mean. Just a sad individual charged with fraud and misconduct. And arson.”

“All at once?”

“I believe so, actually. Quite impressive.”

“Hm.”

The other woman’s eyes narrowed. “You still plan to try them.”

"Well - has anyone actually attempted *these* transmutations? They seem relatively niche, and quite creative. And obviously, Mystacor still holds these records, so they can't have been too outrageous." She flipped a page. "If I could find a safe way out of the boundaries of the curse, I could probably try them."

"You would risk getting mauled to turn me into food? It really is a wonder how you defeated the Horde."

Casta snapped the book shut. "Well, given *your* lack of contribution, I don't think it's any wonder at all."

Shadow Weaver stepped closer. Her gaze was a noxious thing, burning her from the inside out. "Your stubbornness is unbecoming. Surely your time is better spent on other matters."

It was a bit rich coming from the exile squatting in her former place of employment, but Casta simply huffed. "If you are so unwilling to help, I have no issues in doing this myself. I just assumed it would be more efficient with the two of us. Clearly, I forgot who I was working with."

***

"My sword was stolen this morning," Juliet grumbled. "A practical joke, no doubt, even if nobody dares own up to it."

They sat perched on the end of Juliet's bed, alone in the guard barracks. Juliet turned to her wryly. "It's probably a good thing your magic's connected to you. You don't have to deal with nonsense like this."

"I suppose." Casta tried not to bristle at the insinuation that her magic could be likened to a mere weapon. "I don't know where I would be without magic - I've had it my entire life. I use it for everything."

"It's like one of those multi-tools, I'd imagine. I can attest that they're very useful. They've saved my life many times. Not literally, of course. Cabinets. Fixing cabinets." Juliet lay back. The

scar across her nose scrunched adorably as she grinned up. "But I'm rambling. It's good to see you, your Majesty. I'm glad you're here."

"You don't have to call me that," Casta nudged her. "It's Castaspella. Just Castaspella."

"Right." Juliet looked at her shyly. "Castaspella."

***

"Castaspella."

Casta glanced up from the couch. Shadow Weaver lingered an arm width away. When she had appeared, Casta did not know. "The moons align tonight, as I'm sure you're aware," she commented.

"Yes, I know. The eclipse. As things are, I'm glad to be witnessing it at Mystacor once again."

"As am I." The statement lacked its usual bite. Casta's brow furrowed, and she returned to her book.

"Well. I'll be looking out for it. I appreciate the reminder, though."

And yet Shadow Weaver remained, looking at her intently, a twitch of agitation in her stance. After a moment, she turned to pace slowly. "Mystacor holds the traditional festival in the upper gardens for good reason. From there, it is quite a sight to behold." She sniffed. "I suppose you intend to glimpse it from your bedroom window?"

Casta blinked. "What?" At the realisation she leaned back, suddenly amused. "Are you inviting me to join you? I had no idea you were so fond of my company."

Shadow Weaver's voice turned brittle. "Forgive me for assuming that the Head Sorceress might also appreciate the significance of

a sacred event such as this. Of course, such glibness should have been expected from you. Even-" she stopped herself.

Even Micah. The name lay between them, a curse in itself. Her good humour extinguished. She tried to ignore the familiar twinge at the subject of *him* , the never-quite comfortable weakness - a bone healed out of place. "Why?" she snapped. "Why are you so horrible?"

Shadow Weaver exhaled, arms folding. Her cheeks were smudged pink and there was a vague thread of regret in her response. "You do not like talking about him."

"No, I do not! Not with *you,* of all people."

"Very well."

The concession was surprising, but Casta continued to glare at her. The other woman watched her in silence, seeming conflicted. After a long moment, she scoffed. "Really? No sarcastic comment? No last word?"

Shadow Weaver inclined her head. "Will I be seeing you tonight?"

"You are unbelievable." Casta narrowed her eyes. She turned a page, then responded, "If you decide to be civil."

"Then we shall continue our discussion there."

***

The state of her emergency booze stash was the true victim of the current circumstances. She sighed, extracting a bottle of her best aged white wine. From Salineas. Woefully expensive, but worth the occasion.

And it was a beautiful phenomenon. The brief enhancement of magic in the air, the glow of the layered moons stark against the night sky.

She touched the gold hem of her robes. It seemed almost silly to wear the traditional attire when the place was devoid of magic (and people, for that matter), where there would be no singing or dancing or feasting with everyone all giddy in gold. She took a passing glance in the mirror - to an ageless robe and a woman so much older.

Casta shook her head. She picked a couple of glasses from her bed stand and left for the gardens.

Her attire was instantly recognisable - a deep, royal indigo with golden lace, traditional and distinct. A teacher's personalised festival robes. "Light Spinner," she blurted before sense could catch up.

The other sorceress turned, half-shadowed. Some scars glinted silver, while some remained unseen in the dark, and her eyes shone a sharp sea green. Her voice was soft. "She is gone." She regarded Casta through a lowered gaze before stepping aside to reveal a rug, laden with various vegetables, fruits and preserves. "It will be a long night," she added, as if as an explanation.

They sat to watch the moons brighten overhead as the sky itself dimmed. Casta peeked once again at Shadow Weaver, then down at her robes - how strangely she fit them, yet not at all. It didn't go unnoticed, and Shadow Weaver's voice was thoughtful as she spoke.

"Why do you dwell on things of the past?"

"Micah has no interest in things of the past. Especially you."

Casta flinched as the encounter resurfaced, unbidden. "The same reason you do."

Shadow Weaver laughed, humourless. "Because you have no future? Come now, Castaspella. We both know that is far from the truth."

Of course she had a future. She frowned, leaning forward on her elbows. "I know. Regardless of what happens here, I have responsibilities, as an aunt, as a sister…and it's a privilege, it really is. I love my family dearly. But my future is not the same as theirs. Even Micah's place is at Brightmoon. He belongs there. He thrives there."

"Micah would thrive almost anywhere."

"I would expect you to say nothing less."

"It is true, there are few things I would not trust him to do well," Shadow Weaver continued, turning to look at her fully. "But it would be foolish to claim that they do not exist. Dancing, for example. Whatever grace he has in spellcasting is lost in the presence of music." She rose, extending a hand. "I assume you are not so uncoordinated?"

It was baffling. "You want to *dance* with me?"

"Is it not traditional?"

Casta's mouth crept into a half smile as she stood to meet her. "Ask me properly," she ordered.

Shadow Weaver smirked, slitted eyes flashed in challenge. It was almost silly to believe that she would be so easily cowed. But then she dipped her head, drifting closer. "Dance with me," she murmured, low and sincere.

Wordlessly, Casta took her hand, warmth blistering in her belly. They stepped into the pale moonlight, forearms brushing lightly.

"I take it you've done this before."

Shadow Weaver straightened, lips twitching into something wry. "Oh yes, it's a hobby of mine between planning Mystacor's demise and corrupting the youth, as you would say…"

Casta huffed out a laugh. "I honestly can't tell if you're joking."

Shadow Weaver’s hand slipped down to her waist, pulling them closer. “I seldom enjoy company. Is that answer enough?”

They trailed into wordlessness. The waltz felt weightless, trodden with a quiet momentum, like pulling a needle through yarn. Shadow Weaver’s warmth was scalding, and her chest throbbed with something Casta dared not describe lest she scare it or destroy it - a tottering fledgeling in the base of her ribcage. She hardly noticed as they slowed, gente in a matter so foreign to them.

“Do you know of the events that transpired during my last observation of the eclipse in Mystacor?” Her voice tickled Casta’s ear and she pulled back carefully, arms remaining around her neck.

“Yes. The Spell of Obtainment.” Her heart burned. “Do you regret it?”

This time, Shadow Weaver’s fingers brushed along her jaw. “There is little that I do not regret. And for that, I will pay the price.”

“I…” Casta touched her hand, then pulled away, suddenly too close. “We’ll find a way to break it. I am sure of it.”

“Some things are inevitable. And we are out of time.”

Casta paused. “How long do we have?”

“A couple of months, I would wager. No longer.”

Chapter End Notes

> I love these guys, I really do. Wish there was more of them in the show.

Chapter 3

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Light Spinner.”

Micah stood across the courtyard, face dark and stricken. He drew several hexes, hurling them towards her, furious as she cleaved them in twain. They had sent him up here - their best weapon. The other sorcerers were below, battling her forces.

“Did you ever even care?” he drew another, forcing her back. His shoulders were squared. “Have you ever cared about anyone? I trusted you. We *trusted you.”*

She did not respond, staring at him from behind the mask. There was nothing to say. Not anymore.

She watched as he drew another glyph, lightning fast. It was more complicated this time - patterns recognisable but in a novel arrangement.

She blocked it before it came flying, but Micah angled it behind her, striking the rosebush to her side. It wrapped around her, the sensation of being swallowed, squeezed whole.

She knelt, gasping, her power sucked from within.

“Please,” she heard herself whisper, though she was in no place to beg.

“You made your own choices,” Micah said quietly. “I am sorry.”

Shadow Weaver clutched herself. She whimpered, a creature in pain. “Micah,” she crawled forward. Pathetic. “Please.”

Bitterly, Micah plucked a rose from the bush, weaving in his intent as the curse settled. He dropped it at her feet. "Love," he said, turning from her. "True love. It is beyond you."

***

She often longed for her mask. More so now than ever - if only to spare her living partner from the horrors of her features. But it was too late. Her mask had been lost. Shattered. Thrown away as she had accepted a lifetime of solitary confinement.

And so she often retreated herself instead, ugly and alone in the greenhouse with the rose. Sheltered.

"Why do you remain here?" she had been asked as they dawdled in the library, achieving nothing useful. "You aren't bound to Mystacor. I would have expected you to have fled long ago to places with active magic and such."

"And be eaten by wolves?" she had retorted, although she was aware that those, too, were an excuse for them both. She gripped her badge tightly beneath her robe. With a face like hers, there were few places where Brightmoon would not find her. And while she was bound to the curse, magicless…at least here, she was on level ground with any other sorcerer. And it was lonely here. And she preferred it that way.

She gardened, often. She watered her fruit trees and vegetable patches…and her daisies. They were cheerful things, daisies. A wry memory of silly little children's games, tearing away at them innocently. *She loves me, she loves me not. She loves me…*

When "love" was nothing more than an expansion of "like", a simple notion so uncorrupted by herself.

"You must have responsibilities in Brightmoon."

"I do," Castaspella sighed. "Though, not as many as you may think. There aren't as many sorcerers as before, or at least, there

aren’t as many who wish to learn. Not without a school. My efforts are better spent here. This is a priority.”

“It is a waste of time.”

She earned a glare as they sat beside the fountain. “I will return. Once this is over.”

Shadow Weaver studied her. The crease on her forehead, dark lips parted in annoyance. Years ago she might have acted, taken her, used her, if only to steal a part of that fire for her own. She was after all, a parasite in her own way.

Now she simply stood, uneasy, and stalked away.

In the greenhouse, Shadow Weaver glared at the rose, more stem than flower. Three petals remained - the fourth having fallen unnoticed.

She loves me not.

***

The snow had served as an annual displeasure for her over the last six years. It was brittle and wet and the trees would produce little fruit and most of the crops outside the greenhouse would wither. It was especially irritating this time, given that her stock would need to feed two.

She harvested the last of the tomatoes, scowling deeply as Castaspella appeared, bundled in fleece.

“Let me help,” she said.

“There isn’t much left to do. I will return indoors shortly.” She glanced over at Castaspella. “As should you.”

“Oh, no. The grounds look far too lovely.” A mischief coloured her cheeks. She looked oddly like her brother. The thought doused her mood further. “Join me.”

“So we can galavant the school like children?” Shadow Weaver stood, suddenly suspicious. “What-”

A handful of snow splattered near her cheek, wet and cold. She coughed, furious. “You dare - I will not engage in your -” she ducked as another was thrown her way, grabbing at Castaspella’s arms in an attempt to stop her.

She managed to seize her coat as the woman twisted to the side, and they both tumbled, slamming into the snow.

Castaspella pinned her, breath condensing and eyes shining, copper-brown. There was a gentle curve to her smile. Inviting. Shadow Weaver panted beneath. Her words lacked any force behind them.

“Get off me.”

Immediately, Casta pushed away, though her expression stayed. “My first-years were better than you at this,” she laughed lightly.

“Mine dared not find out,” Shadow Weaver muttered, quashing any burgeoning affection and returning to the vegetables.

She looked briefly at the rose as she slipped into bed, three petals remaining still. Irritated, she turned over.

***

“You don’t wear your mask.”

They lay in the Head Sorcerer’s quarters, carelessly languid after a drink or two. Castaspella had offered despite there being no apparent occasion, and Shadow Weaver now blinked at the starlit roof, wondering if she should be feeling regretful.

“Would you prefer it if I did?”

Castaspella snorted. “Certainly not. That thing still gives me nightmares. Besides, it’s absolutely hideous.”

Well, then. It must suit me well. Shadow Weaver turned Castaspella's words over in her mind. "I never considered you to be fearful of me."

"Oh, no. A grand and *powerful* sorceress like myself? Fearful? Please." She shifted, leaning on an elbow. Her voice lilted playfully. "You shouldn't worry. I don't dream of you like that anymore. I haven't for a while."

Shadow Weaver turned her head. "And in what way do you dream of me now?"

She skimmed over her outline in the dim, hair loose around her. They lay so close that Shadow Weaver could feel her warmth beside her. Castaspella exhaled a laugh.

"As if you actually care."

"If I did not care, I would not ask."

She watched the dip of her lashes, the darkness of her eyes like the tug of molasses, slow and gentle, irresistibly sweet. Her heart fluttered as the other woman leaned closer, their foreheads brushing. But then Castaspella stopped, breathing deeply against her.

"Shadow Weaver…" She pulled back gently. "I asked you to come for a reason. I need to tell you that I intend to leave. I have made no progress on the curse…and I'm already too attached. To Mystacor, that is."

Shadow Weaver closed her eyes. "I see." The rasp in her voice betrayed her. She was a ruined woman. Fated for death. She was not worth staying for.

"I am unlikely to return. But I can seek more help in Brightmoon… from Micah, even, if you wish."

"He would not help me." She rolled over on her back. "He would not know how to." *I do not want his help. I do not want any of*

them.

She woke several hours later to a dark room, Castaspella's figure curled in a ball, snoring lightly beside her. Silently, Shadow Weaver rose. She carefully drew the duvet over her sleeping form and left the room.

When she returned to the greenhouse, she glared at the three petals, stubborn and unmoving, something sharp lodged in her chest.

***

They stood at the gate. Shadow Weaver extended her sorcerer guild's badge. "The magic within it is protected. Use it to return home safely." *To remember me,* a voice added quietly in her mind, though she brushed it away as disgustingly sentimental.

"Magic." She did not need to see Castaspella's face to know her surprise. *Why stay if you had magic his entire time? Why not use it? Why not kill me?*

"Go," Shadow Weaver said softly.

She watched her pause, then nod, then step beyond the gate, badge in hand. She drew a glyph. And disappeared.

Shadow Weaver returned to the greenhouse. To her bed and her vegetables. To her pile of books. Her gaze passed over the rose in its glass jar.

A petal fell.

And she smiled bitterly despite herself.

***

Shaking, Casta opened her palm. The badge lay, limp, the grit of dust between her fingers. Brightmoon's castle lay before her. She

felt lightheaded without the curse, the return of magic like pins and needles down her spine.

Stretching her fingers, she swallowed and scanned the grounds. From ahead, she could see a poof of pink hair hurrying towards her at quite an alarming pace. “Aunt Casta?” Glimmer’s eyes were wide. “You’re back! Is Mystacor okay? Dad wanted to send a search party after you - what happened?”

Casta’s arms wrapped around her in a habitual gesture. “Actually, I should find your father,” she heard herself say. “Is he home?”

“Yes. He’s with Frosta in the gardens. Building snowme- sorry, snow *golems* .” Glimmer’s brow knitted. “Are you sure you’re okay?”

“Oh, yes, I’m fine!” Casta turned. “It’s wonderful to see you, but I’d best be off now. I’d love to catch up later, really.” She smiled, then headed into the castle.

She passed Juliet on her way down the hall, helmet off, talking to Bow. She glanced up at Casta, who gave her a single nod. Juliet smiled, then returned to her conversation.

“Oh. Perfuma.” She stepped into the gardens, mind spinning, knowing that she *shouldn’t* ask, that she would leave the subject alone and allow Shadow Weaver to pass in peace, but, oh, well, nevermind. The woman’s beaming smile soon faded as Casta spoke.

“I need to pick your brain, actually. On roses, that is. Would you happen to know how long they last, say, compared to the average flower? And by that, I mean things like *dandelions,* or daffodils or daisies, or…peonies? And - very well, maybe those aren’t *average* flowers - you would know better than *I* do about that, but I really don’t know many other flowers except for the ones in my spellbooks, which *you* probably don’t know very well - no offence to your knowledge of course, you know more about flowers than anyone - but I digress. Really, would the lifespan of a rose change

if you, say, *froze them?* Are they even counted as alive if they're frozen? And really..."

"Casta?"

She turned back to see Micah approaching.

"I mean, roses can usually last around fourteen days with proper care?" Perfuma responded. "I'm not sure how to answer that, exactly. Um. It's nice to see you anyway, Castaspella. Good luck on your research." She left.

"Casta!" Micah pulled her into a bear hug. "I nearly went after you. I sent you a few letters, but I don't think the posting system works anymore."

"It wouldn't." Casta hugged him back tightly. "You were right. The curse is still in effect. There is no active magic there at all. I couldn't find a way to break it."

"It's still there?" Micah pulled away, concern shifting over his features. He examined her. "Why didn't you come back sooner? Here, I'll get you some food. A hot bath. Being under the effects of a curse like that for so long…it's not good for you."

"I'm fine, Micah. Really." She chewed the inside of her mouth. "I need your help. We need to find a way to break it - one that *doesn't* involve destroying the vessel."

"Could you not find it? I believe I hit a rosebush… maybe we just give it a break for now…"

"We're just going to give up? Oh, Micah, if only we implemented a way to break it…a fail safe, a *condition,* how could we be so foolish? There must be some other way…surely you have some idea? I just…I have to…"

He must have seen it in her eye. Colour drained from his face. "She's there, isn't she?"

“Micah…”

“Stay.” His voice trembled fiercely as he stepped away from her. “Stay . I will handle this.”

No. She stepped forward, voice turned soft, pleading. “She’s different… she’s *dying… ”*

“She’s *bad for people.* She ruins people. She has threatened my family too many times!” His chest heaved, calm facade shattered. “I have made a grave mistake. I am so sorry. I will not allow her to reach Glimmer..or Brightmoon..or *you.”*

“I am an *adult* , Micah!” Her throat burned with protests and explanations…and apologies. Micah had not seen her gentle remorse, he had not felt her touch, he did not understand the sensation of being seen by her, inside and out. But the confession shrivelled to ash on her tongue. She should not be feeling this way. Steeling herself, she asked instead, “What are you going to do?”

“I will finish what we began.”

***

She had returned from a place without magic…to yet another place without magic.

Casta slumped back onto the pillows Glimmer had kindly provided, because firstly, she was not a “real prisoner” and secondly, because Brightmoon’s holding chamber was a joke.

“Glimmer, I just intend to made sure your father doesn’t make any rash decisions. Let me go with him. Please.”

“She’s dangerous, Auntie. Dad’s worried she’s gotten into your head…and so am I.”

She was so concerned, so tender, and Casta likely would have sobbed, moved by such care, if she was not being *wrangled by*

guards . The audacity.

She stared at the ceiling, suddenly wishing she was back in her bed at Mystacor with Shadow Weaver, whispering admissions to one another.

He would not help me. He would not know how to.

Shadow Weaver had no idea. She had no defence, no magic, she had given her protected source to Casta. She would die believing Casta had betrayed her.

Her hand dropped to her chest in a jolting realisation. The badge.

She unclipped it swiftly, shaking out a few specks of dust. Not much. Not enough to teleport directly back to Mystacor.

Hurriedly, she drew the glyph. It was small and scraggly…but it would do.

She teleported to the stables. Clambering onto the nearest horse, she raced forth.

***

The wolves were waiting for her about ten yards from the gate.

"Are you kidding me? *Go away ! "*

She launched herself off the horse, crashing through the gate. Her horse reared and whinnied behind her. It raced away, chased off by several wolves. Dizzy and half winded, she slammed the gate shut and made haste for the west tower.

Her heart thumped wildly.

Perhaps Shadow Weaver would be alone…or perhaps not. Maybe Micah was there, hovering over her body. Or maybe the rose had been destroyed…maybe she was already long gone.

Casta rounded the building, scrambling up the staircase. She blinked away a vivid memory of scurrying after her brother with grazed knees.

"Come on slug feet!"

"Aw, Micah! Slow down!"

She stumbled onto the second floor, ears straining.

"…dangerous."

There was a murmur of a reply, muffled by the wind.

From below, she could distinguish two figures on the balcony. She could see Micah's sword pointed forward. Her brother was shaking.

She raced up the last flight of stairs in an instant, stepping forth to shield the other woman. Micah softened in her presence, but his sword remained drawn.

"Micah, please." She tried to sound as dignified as she could whilst gasping for breath. "I understand what you think, but *please.* Give her a chance."

A hand touched her shoulder. Shadow Weaver spoke quietly. "You came back."

Her heart burned. Casta swallowed, covering her hand before glancing back at Micah. He was looking at Shadow Weaver, forehead creased in a mix of fear and disgust. "What have you done to her?"

"I have done *nothing."*

Micah's eyes flashed as he pushed forward, but Casta struggled against him.

"I gave you a chance once," Micah spat. "Clearly I made a mistake. Why didn't you run away? Why couldn't you just *leave?"* He turned to Casta. "Step away," he told her. "Casta, get away from her. Please."

"I won't." Casta was unmoving. "Let her be, Micah."

His shoulders bunched, fearful and angry. He stepped back.

Coldly, he produced the rose.

At once, Casta rushed forward, outstretched, but it was too late. He crushed it in one fluid movement. "I am sorry," he said in anguish.

Shadow Weaver spasmed behind her, crumpling to the ground.

"Oh no… *no.* I-" Casta's voice staggered. She knelt, holding her, cradling her. "It wasn't supposed to be like this. No. You…you're okay. I never should have left, I never….please."

She couldn't die now, not when she had found her, not when she had come back, not when she finally had her.

Her voice cracked and she touched her face, stroked her cheek, those sordid truths, so private and held so closely, pouring out of her in desperate whispers. "Please," she whispered brokenly. "You can't leave me. I - I love you. I *love* you."

The woman lay limp and cold beneath her. Magic throbbed, bittersweet in her chest. The curse was broken, of course. There was no curse without a vessel. Without the rose…and Shadow Weaver…

A hand touched her cheek, and she stiffened. She looked down. Shadow Weaver gazed up at her, eyes glittering with affection.

She stared.

"You." Casta choked, disbelieving. "You…you're alive?" She laughed, then frowned, then glared at her, bewildered. "How - *what?* You - I-" her stomach swooped and she pulled back, aghast. "You *heard -"*

Shadow Weaver chuckled, then drew her close, pressing her mouth to Casta's. The question melted away as she pulled her closer, deepening the kiss, both of them caring little about Micah's awkward shuffle in the distance.

***

She knew the stories they told.

There were fewer of them now that she was no longer declared officially dead (she was deemed as less exciting now), but comments from the occasional unruly child informed her of their existence. They weren't exactly subtle, either.

"I'll sell you my brother," someone's offspring had announced to her earlier after giving her a quick appraisal. *"He's quite robust. I'd imagine he'd taste quite juicy."*

Not that she was in the proximity of children, much. She had been banned from teaching during her trial in Brightmoon. Her sentence, as decided by Brightmoon's spineless council, was a lifetime of community service. And a discussion with Micah, of course.

"If you ever do anything to hurt her…" he'd warned fiercely, and she had pursed her lips.

"Spare me the antics, Micah. Your point has already been made."

"That is true." He seemed a little rueful for a moment, but his expression quickly sobered. *"Treat her well."*

Her.

Castaspella.

Her Castaspella. She burst through the door now, adjusting her halo and looking positively dishevelled. “Do you have *any idea* of the number of papers I need to mark? It’s ridiculous! Really - maybe I should drop a class or two, but with such an influx of students and half the staff on sick leave... the finals are due tomorrow, too.”

“You are overworked. As usual.” Shadow Weaver leaned against the Head Sorcerer’s desk, head tilted. She rose, tucking a hair behind her partner’s ear. “I will deal with the papers for now. Go. Rest.”

It had been six years. To say that all of the kingdoms liked, or even tolerated her would be a flagrant mistruth. But they respected the Head Sorcerer’s judgement. She would have time to earn their trust.

Castaspella, who now had her arms wrapped around Shadow Weaver’s neck. “Thank you” she sighed. Slowly, she released her and headed to the bathroom, but then stopped, running a hand through her hair. “School ends tomorrow. Dine with me afterwards?”

Shadow Weaver watched her, heart quickening. She knew that she did not deserve forgiveness, or Castaspella, or the life she lived today. But she had entertained death for too many years. Living freely, she decided, tasted that much sweeter.

Chapter End Notes

And it's done! Thanks for reading. Hope you liked it.

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